

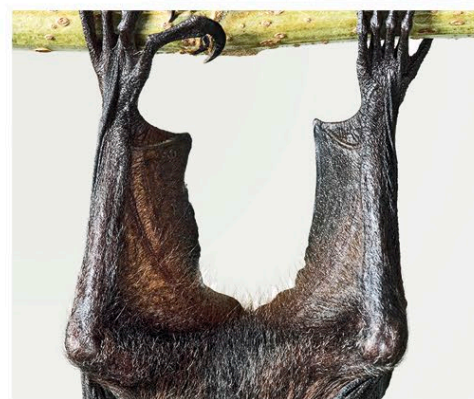
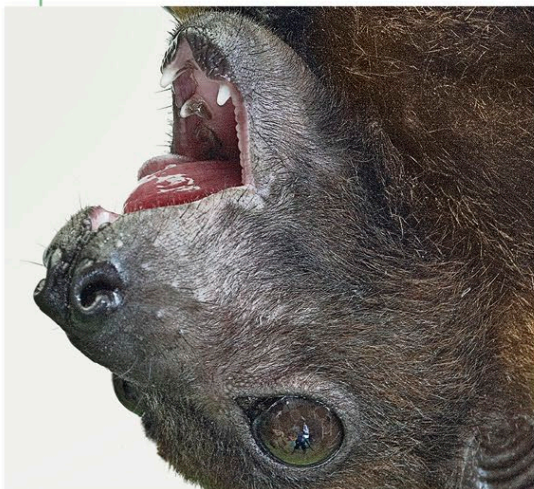
LYLE'S FLYING FOX

Pteropus lylei

Lyle's flying fox is a medium-sized representative of the Old World fruit bat family, the Pteropodidae. Fruit bats are social animals; many hundreds may gather in roost trees during the day to rest and groom, dispersing at dusk to find ripe fruits. Although they may cause some damage to trees, many fruit bats are important pollinators and seed dispersers of tropical plants, including many commercial crops. Fruit bats are found in the tropical regions of Africa, Asia, and Australia, although this species is only found in Cambodia, Thailand, and Vietnam. They inhabit forested areas, including mangroves and fruit orchards.

✓ CANINE FACE

Fruit bats have large eyes for navigation and a large nose for sniffing out fruits, pollen, and nectar — giving them a dog-like face. Species that use echolocation have larger ears and smaller eyes.



^ TAIL OR NO TAIL?

Pteropus bats lack a tail, but some have a partial membrane supported by cartilaginous spurs called calcars, which protrude from the ankle.

WALKING UPSIDE DOWN >

Fruit bats use their large clawed thumbs to help them move along the branches of their roost tree.

The claw can also be used to manipulate fruit when feeding.



< CLINGING CLAWS

Bats' sharp, curved claws are perfect for clinging on to tree branches. When roosting, tendons lock in place to ensure the bat's claws stay bent without the muscles needing to contract.



^ HAND WING

A bat's wing is formed of elongated forearm and finger bones supporting a thin elastic membrane attached to the sides of the body. It has a large surface area, giving lift in flight.



SIZE 16–24 cm (6½–9½ in)

HABITAT Forests

DISTRIBUTION S.E. and E. Asia

DIET Fruits and leaves

all bats have a thumb claw, but only Old World fruit bats have a claw on the second finger too



^ WELL WRAPPED

When resting, most fruit bats hang upside down with their leathery wings folded around their bodies. Bats roosting in the open risk overheating, so they flap their wings and cover themselves in saliva to help keep cool in hot weather.